



Fundamentals of Human Resource Management (HRM1)

Module 7: Job Analysis, Design and Evaluation

Lesson 1: Job Analysis

Lesson Notes

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What Is Job Analysis, and What Does It Actually Study

Job analysis is the process of collecting relevant information required to perform a job, identifying and determining the specific duties, requirements, and relative importance of those duties. An important principle underlies the whole process: job analysis studies the job, not the person. Even though information may be collected from the people currently holding the job, through interviews or questionnaires, the actual product of the analysis is a description or specification of the job itself, not a judgement of the individual (Dessler, 2016).

This produces two distinct documents. A job description is a written statement listing the purpose, duties, and working conditions of a particular job. A job specification is a written statement of the minimum acceptable qualifications an incumbent must possess to perform that job successfully.

Job analysis collects information across five areas. Duties and tasks cover the frequency, duration, effort, skill, and complexity of the work performed. Environment covers physical conditions, which in some roles may include genuine hazards such as toxic fumes or hostile situations. Tools and equipment covers the specific items, including protective clothing, needed to perform the job. Relationships covers supervision given and received, and interactions with people inside and outside the organisation. Requirements cover the knowledge, skills, and abilities needed, noting only what the job requires, not necessarily what a particular incumbent happens to possess.

A security guard role at a Ugandan shopping mall in Kampala illustrates these five areas clearly: duties include patrolling and monitoring entrances, the environment may involve standing for long hours and occasional confrontation, tools include a radio and uniform, relationships include reporting to a security supervisor, and requirements include basic literacy and physical fitness.

Methods of Collecting Job Analysis Information

The choice of method depends on practical concerns: the type of job, the number of jobs and incumbents involved, and their location.

The questionnaire method gives incumbents a structured form to identify duties, responsibilities, equipment, relationships, and environment, which a job analyst then reviews with the supervisor for accuracy before preparing the final job description. This method works well where large numbers of incumbents hold the same role, though it risks missing information the incumbent does not think to mention or misunderstands.

The observation method involves the analyst directly watching incumbents perform their work, and suits roles with observable, physical activity, such as machine operators, construction workers, or bus drivers. Its advantage is eliminating the errors of omission or exaggeration that come from relying on someone's own description of their job, and it can even support legal testimony, since direct observation is not treated as hearsay. Its main weakness is that people often alter their behaviour when they know they are being watched, and it is poorly suited to jobs involving mostly mental rather than physical activity.

The interview method asks incumbents directly to describe their tasks and duties, and can be unstructured, a free flowing conversation guided loosely by the interviewer's purpose, or structured, following a defined format such as charting a sequence of activities using a set questionnaire. Interviews allow jobholders to explain non-observable aspects of their work and offer their own perceptions, but are time consuming, require skilled interviewers, and carry a real risk of the incumbent exaggerating or omitting details, or of interviewer bias distorting the picture.

A Ugandan hospital analysing the role of a ward nurse might combine observation, since much of the role is physically visible, with structured interviews, since nurses also carry judgement based responsibilities such as triage decisions that observation alone would not capture.

Reflect: For a role you are familiar with, would questionnaire, observation, or interview be the most practical method of job analysis, and why?

Why Job Analysis Matters Across the HR Function

Job analysis exists to establish and document the job relatedness of employment procedures such as training, selection, compensation, and performance appraisal. It supports five major HR activities.

In determining training needs, job analysis identifies what training content is required, what tests should measure training effectiveness, what equipment training should use, and what training method, classroom, on the job, or computer based, fits the role best. In compensation, job analysis identifies the skill levels, environmental hazards, responsibilities, and education required, all of which feed into how a role is priced relative to others. In selection procedures, job analysis shapes job advertisements, appropriate salary offers, minimum requirements for screening, interview questions, and selection tests. In performance review, job analysis identifies the goals, standards, and evaluation criteria a role should actually be judged against, rather than criteria borrowed from an unrelated role. Finally, job analysis supports role clarity, reducing ambiguity about what an employee is actually meant to be doing, which itself reduces conflict and confusion in day to day work.

A Ugandan microfinance institution that skips proper job analysis when creating a new loan officer role risks writing a vague job advertisement, hiring the wrong candidate, setting unrealistic performance targets, and then unfairly blaming the employee when performance falls short, when the real problem was an undefined role from the start.

Reflect: *Of training, compensation, selection, performance review, and role clarity, which do you think suffers most when an organisation skips job analysis entirely?*